temperature. Maybe that is why people often remark how at home they feel. Isak Dinesen said it, but we all say it when we're in Kenya. And the people are friendly. For someone like me, who has always been on the road, there was this sense of generosity and general satisfaction that this was the place to be. The rates of crime and the incidence of Aids, of course, are very high, but if I felt at all tense on our way to Kisumu and the Commonwealth Games Stadium, it was because I felt so sure that this visit would be crucial to the development of WikiLeaks.

'Think global, act local' had long been an article of faith among the left-wingers that predominantly made up the crowd at the World Social Forum, but I preferred to see things slightly differently. When the world only extended to your surrounding villages, hills and mountains, and beyond them was only legend, saving the world was approachable and a natural activity to all of independent character. But in the modern world, one needs only a minimum of education and a little access to the media to realise how vast the world is. And this fact is demoralising. It is impossible to envisage your actions making any significant difference. To interact meaningfully with the world, one either has to constrain one's imagination – to artificially shrink the world – or try in some way to really engage with the world as you perceive it now, information overload and all. I was becoming convinced that this second option was the only way to achieve real change, and coming to Africa was in a way an attempt to test that out, to see whether WikiLeaks could be an organisation that 'thought globally and acted globally'.

Nairobi was quite wild, in a way. We were staying in tents, three tents, as it happens, one built inside the other to avoid mosquitoes (fat chance), and we quickly found ourselves helping to organise the recording, translation and archiving of the events at the forum. At one point I moved into the president's suite at the stadium. It was thought to be a good centre from which to co-ordinate things. A large desk, cheap Georgian furniture everywhere, and paintings of former president Daniel Arap Moi looking down from the sun-bleached walls. The corridors were lined with female security officers bearing wooden truncheons. On one of the days there was a commotion in the corridor and suddenly, out of nowhere, a crowd of Kenyan Communist Party members came bustling down the hall, pressing the guards and everyone else to the walls as they entered our makeshift office. They were accompanied by a large press pack carrying notebooks